Solving for X: Unexpected Variables
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Solving for X: Unexpected Variables

by Lunaeryi

Summary

Tutoring was supposed to be about math. Instead, Mydei ended up pinned to a desk, kissed breathless, and left wondering why the hell his hot classmate tasted like chocolate almonds and chaos. Homework: incomplete. Feelings: very inconvenient.

Notes

Extremely rushed, all I’m gonna say abt this😭 (Gotta keep myself from burning out until I finish Paper Cuts and Pyres)

See the end of the work for more notes

The last bell had rung nearly an hour ago. The halls were quiet now—just the hum of the heater kicking on, and the soft creak of pipes overhead.

Inside the third-floor classroom, golden light poured through the windows in long streaks, casting the desks in angled amber. The chalkboard still had remnants of equations scrawled half-erased. The smell of dry-erase markers and old wood hung in the air.

Mydei sat in the far back, hood up, one leg kicked out beneath the desk. Earbuds in—music low—but he wasn't listening.

He was mouthing words, barely audible. *"Mitochondria. ATP cycle. Glycolysis…"*

Every now and then, he'd frown and glance down at his notes, muttering a correction under his breath. One page had a tiny rip near the corner from where he'd clenched it too hard. Another had some barely-visible pencil indentations where he'd tried to scratch out a math formula and failed—again.

He sighed, quietly. "Stupid numbers."

Everyone thought he was dumb. Or violent. Or both. The thug with the sharp eyes and permanent slouch, who once got sent to detention for *"cornering a classmate."* No one cared that he'd only been correcting the kid on the Bohr model of the atom. Loudly.

And now, thanks to that—and his father's "generous support" of the school—he had to sit through mandatory tutoring. To "clean up his record." Appearances had to be maintained.

Of course, his one academic Achilles heel had to be the one subject he couldn't brute-force: math.

The door opened.

"Mydei~"

Speak of the devil.

He didn’t look up.

Phainon’s voice was as irritatingly cheerful as ever, but his footsteps were light. Too smooth for someone carrying a stuffed canvas bag in one hand and a clipboard in the other.

“Ready to face your greatest enemy yet?”

Mydei opened one eye.

“You?”

Phainon grinned, sunlight catching on his student council badge like it was part of the act. “Math.”

He dropped the bag on the desk next to Mydei with a dramatic *thud*. Something inside rustled.

“Don’t worry. I brought offerings.”

Mydei gave the bag a sidelong glance. “If there’s celery sticks in there, I’m walking.”

Phainon laughed. “Please. I know you better than that.”

He pulled out a pack of sour gummies and dropped it on Mydei’s desk like he was placing a bribe. Then followed it with a small stack of flashcards, a mechanical pencil, and a neon pink eraser shaped like a cat.

Mydei stared at the eraser. Then at him. “Seriously?”

“It’s a morale booster,” Phainon said placidly, taking the seat across from him. “Studies show tactile stimulation improves retention.”

“You made that up.”

“I did. But you’re thinking about it, aren’t you?”

Mydei rolled his eyes and sank a little lower in his seat. But he didn’t shove the eraser away.

Instead, he quietly opened the sour gummies and popped one into his mouth.

Phainon fell onto the seat next to Mydei, and stretched like he hadn’t just climbed three flights of stairs at full speed.

Arms overhead, fingers laced, spine arching until his back gave a satisfying *crack*.

“Alright,” he sighed, like this was some kind of spa day. “Let’s get those neurons firing.”

Mydei didn’t look at him right away. He kept his head turned toward the window, watching dust float in the slanting gold light. The city beyond the glass was already softening into dusk.

Next to him, Phainon was flipping open a folder and shuffling index cards like a magician about to do a card trick. Somehow his hair was always just this side of tousled, like he’d sprinted through a wind tunnel and come out looking on *brand*.

It was annoying.

Not just the sunshine energy. Or the fact that Phainon always had the right pens and fresh paper. Or that he treated tutoring like a club meeting he was excited to host.

It was the fact that he was *good at this*.

Head of the student council. Top scorer in half the mock exams. Somehow both a dork and a public figure, with a schedule so packed it should’ve crushed him. But he smiled through all of it like he didn’t notice the weight. Like he liked it.

Scholarship student, probably. Mydei didn’t know for sure—didn’t ask. But there were whispers.

And back when they were kids—

He blinked. Let the thought play out in his head anyway.

Back when they were kids, it was different.

They'd met in elementary, both too loud for their grade and too stubborn to ever agree on anything. Argued over trivia like it was war. Got banned from the library once for fighting over a science encyclopedia. Came back the next week with matching scrapes and a pact to build a homemade seismograph.

And then at some point—they just weren't anymore.

It wasn't anything dramatic. Mydei wasn't sure what changed. Maybe it was middle school. Or maybe high school just pulled them into different currents. Phainon got busier. Mydei got quieter. They ended up in different classes. Different crowds.

Now?

They didn't talk. Not really. Except for this—this strange, school-mandated meeting of academic opposites.

He glanced over finally, just in time to catch Phainon popping open a box of chocolate-covered almonds like they were brain fuel.

"Snacks," Phainon offered, holding them out with a hopeful little lift of his eyebrows.

"No," Mydei said automatically.

Phainon left the box on his desk anyway.

Then, with a satisfied little sigh, he clicked his pen open like a sword being drawn.

"Okay. Let's tackle this beast. What's got you shaking in your boots today? Quadratic equations or exponents?"

Mydei stared at him. Then, dry as bone: “Your voice.”

Phainon beamed. “Ah. Advanced sarcasm. We’re starting strong today.”

Time skipped forward like chalk dust in the sunlight.

The lesson was in full swing now—scrap paper spread between them, formulas sketched in smooth loops, Mydei’s handwriting steadily tightening as he worked through problem after problem. His knee bounced under the desk, but his pencil moved with purpose.

It was annoying. Infuriating, really.

Phainon was actually a good tutor.

Not just competent—*annoyingly effective.* He explained things with clarity, broke down concepts without condescension, and never once lost patience, even when Mydei hesitated.

Which would’ve been fine. Great, even.

If he didn’t whisper equations like they were secrets meant only for *his* ears.

“Almost there,” Phainon murmured beside him, voice low and warm. “Just carry the two. Careful. You almost—”

His shoulder bumped Mydei’s.

His breath brushed his ear.

Mydei’s pencil stuttered.

He gritted his teeth and finished the line, jaw tight.

It wasn’t the math. He could handle the math.

It was the *delivery*.

Phainon was too close. Way too close. He leaned in every time Mydei got something right, like praise was a contact sport. His hand would casually nudge Mydei's when he passed over a new problem, fingers brushing just a second too long. He spoke like this was some kind of puzzle date and not the seventh circle of algebra hell.

And when Mydei finally solved one of the tougher questions—a whole damn equation without error—Phainon lit up like a reward screen.

"Oh? Look at you." His voice dropped to a mock-whisper. "Didn't even need a hint."

Before Mydei could deflect, Phainon leaned in, resting his chin on the heel of his hand, elbow on the desk, smile smug and soft all at once.

Then—without warning—he picked up a chocolate almond, and pressed it right to Mydei's lips.

"Open," he said, like this was normal.

Mydei did not open.

So Phainon just *pressed* it a little more insistently.

It landed square in his mouth.

He almost choked.

Phainon blinked innocently. "Reward system, remember?"

Mydei chewed stiffly, resisting the urge to throw his pencil across the room. He focused on the paper. Focused on his own handwriting. On the numbers. On literally anything but the boy who kept smiling like *that*.

It was totally a coincidence that his scores were better today.

Completely unrelated.

He just liked sweets. That was all. He didn’t want to grab them himself because—manners. Yeah. They weren’t *his* snacks, and reaching over would’ve been rude. Obviously.

Seeing Phainon’s face up close—his blue eyes, the curve of his smile, the way his lashes caught the light—had nothing to do with it. Why would it?

He cleared his throat and shifted his chair back half an inch.

Just enough to give himself breathing room.

Definitely not because his ears were red.

Phainon tilted his head, clearly not missing the way Mydei had retreated half an inch.

“Oh?” he said, voice dipped in faux concern. “Too much praise? Should I be meaner next time?”

Mydei scowled and focused aggressively on erasing a number.

Phainon leaned in again anyway, lower this time, like he was trying to peek under the hoodie’s shadow. “You’re blushing.”

“I’m hot,” Mydei muttered.

“Yeah,” Phainon said. “You are.”

Mydei’s hand froze on the page.

There was a very small pause—so small it barely registered—and then Phainon leaned back, all sunshine again, like he hadn’t just lit a fuse and tossed it over his shoulder.

Mydei didn’t respond. He didn’t *have* a response. His ears were hot again and the numbers were starting to blur and he hated that this tutoring session was turning into whatever *this* was.

He risked a glance toward Phainon—intent on snapping something, anything, back—but his gaze caught on something unexpected.

Faint, just above the wrist where Phainon's blazer had ridden up.

A burn mark. Small, round, like a cigarette scar.

Old, maybe. Not ancient.

And when Phainon shifted to grab another sheet of paper, Mydei caught the edge of a keychain tucked just behind the lapel of his blazer. Chrome glinted.

Not a novelty charm.

A lockpick.

Mydei's brow twitched.

He didn't say anything. Didn't ask.

Just leaned back in his chair and gave Phainon a look—dry, unimpressed, the kind that meant *I see that, and I'm filing it away for later.*

Phainon met his gaze like nothing was out of place.

"Something wrong?" he asked, too innocently.

Mydei shrugged. "Are we done yet?"

Phainon grinned. "Almost. Unless you want a bonus round."

"No."

"You sure?"

"I'll bite you."

Phainon just smiled wider. "Promises, promises."

They wrapped up not long after that.

Phainon packed up his notes with a practiced ease, humming something off-key under his breath. He offered Mydei the last chocolate almond with an open palm and an obnoxiously hopeful look.

Mydei snatched it wordlessly, then muttered, “I’m not a dog.”

“Then stop acting like a cat,” Phainon chirped. “All hisses and no gratitude.”

“I said thank you in my head.”

Phainon chuckled, shouldered his bag, and gave him a lazy salute before heading out. “Same time next week, delinquent.”

Mydei rolled his eyes but didn’t correct him. He waited until the hallway was quiet again before leaving.

The sky outside was tinted lavender, the sun dropping below the school buildings as the gold bled out of the clouds. Mydei shoved his hands into his hoodie pocket, hood up again, and started the walk home.

The streets were mostly empty this late—just the sound of cicadas and the occasional bike wheel clicking past. He didn’t mind the quiet.

He told himself he was thinking about the math problems. That they were still spinning somewhere in the back of his mind. He’d gotten more of them right today. Maybe it was starting to click.

But somewhere between the crosswalk and the vending machine he always passed without using, he realized he was thinking about Phainon.

Not in full thoughts—just flickers. The way he leaned in when explaining things. That stupid smile. The burn on his wrist. The keychain. His voice when he said You are.

They hadn’t really talked since middle school. Not properly. Not since Phainon transferred for a year and came back all cleaned up and polished. Back then, they used to argue about everything—who could run faster, who had the better rocks, who could name more dinosaurs.

Back then, Phainon had braces and crooked bangs and a bad habit of tripping over his own feet.

Now he looked like he belonged in a student council recruitment poster. Golden boy. Teacher favorite. The kind of guy no one would expect to know how to break into a supply closet.

Or say you are in a voice that made your thoughts skip three steps.

Mydei exhaled through his nose. Adjusted his hood.

It didn’t matter.

It was just tutoring.

Just math.

Right?

Steam still curled lazily from Mydei’s damp skin as he stepped out of the showers, toweling his hair with one hand and yawning into the other. His breath fogged in the chilled air of the locker room—always colder after practice. The dull buzz of the overhead lights hummed above him as he walked barefoot across the tile, muscle memory guiding him toward his locker.

Basketball practice had been nothing special. He scored, blocked, sprinted, didn’t speak unless someone spoke to him first. It was his usual rhythm—good enough to carry the team half the time, intimidating enough that no one questioned him when he showed up late or ditched warm-up drills. The coach tolerated it. Mydei got results.

He peeled his towel from around his shoulders and reached for his shirt, absently checking his reflection in the scratched metal of the locker door as he moved. His build was the kind that turned heads in the hallway, broad-shouldered and sharp-edged. Not that he cared, let them spread as much rumors as they want.

(He definitely didn't notice the way some first-years went quiet when he passed them in gym clothes.)

The scent of clean sweat and soap clung to him as he tugged on a fresh hoodie, already drying from the shower but letting his sleeves hang loose while he cooled off. He cracked his neck once, sighed, and grabbed his bag —

—and froze.

There was a folded note tucked into the edge of the locker door.

Not unusual.

Phainon had a habit. Little reminders, usually dumb, scribbled in colored pen like a teacher writing on a quiz.

"*Don't forget tutoring <3"*

"Bring snacks or perish."

"Bet I can make you solve for x in under ten minutes. Let's test that ego."

This one was different.

No emoji, no exclamation point. Just one line, in neat, curved handwriting:

"Can't wait to see that cute confused face again."

Mydei stared at it for a full five seconds before his brain restarted.

What.

He read it again. And again. The words didn’t change.

His first instinct was *no way*—Phainon probably meant to give this to someone else. A joke? A dare? Accidentally slipped it into the wrong locker?

Except it was his handwriting. That little swoop in the “g” at the end. The same kind of paper. Same blue pen.

Mydei blinked, brain sluggishly buffering.

Was this… flirting?

No. No way. Probably just… some weird layered insult.

…Right?

He shoved the note into his pocket like it might explode if someone else saw it.

Then he realized something even worse: his face felt warm.

Mydei scowled, yanked his bag over his shoulder, and muttered under his breath:

“…I’m gonna kill him.”

The student council meeting was in full swing.

Sort of.

Phainon sat at the head of the polished oak table, legs casually crossed, pen spinning between his fingers as one of the junior reps explained the Photography Club’s request for extended room access.

“—just an hour or two after school on Thursdays,” the rep said nervously, shuffling their papers. “They’ve promised to clean up and everything—”

“That’s fine,” Phainon said without looking up. “Just make sure they leave the lights off when they’re done. We don’t need another power bill incident.”

A few of the council members chuckled lightly. Someone jotted it down in the minutes.

All was calm.

Peaceful.

Controlled.

And then the door slammed open so hard the walls shook.

Every head in the room snapped toward the noise. One of the juniors nearly fell out of their chair. A second-year gasped loud enough to echo.

There, in the doorway, stood Mydei.

Still slightly damp from his post-practice shower, hoodie up, gym bag slung carelessly over one shoulder. The kind of expression that made freshmen question their life choices. His eyes locked onto Phainon like a heat-seeking missile.

“Uh—sir—do you want us to call—?” one rep whispered to Phainon in a panic, half-rising from their seat.

Another nervously added, “We can file a report if he’s here to complain—”

“I’m not here to complain,” Mydei said flatly, stepping into the room. “I’m here to ask what the *hell* this is.”

He pulled the note from his pocket and slapped it onto the table in front of Phainon.

Phainon blinked at it.

“Oh,” he said brightly. “That wasn’t today’s note.”

“You *think*?” Mydei snapped.

“Language,” Phainon said automatically, then glanced down at the writing and let out a small, innocent: “Ah. My hands slipped.”

The entire council was frozen in stunned silence.

Mydei didn’t say anything. He just *looked* at him, murder simmering under barely restrained annoyance.

Phainon, unfazed, picked up the note and waved it gently like a fan. “But you did read it. So. Technically that counts as a compliment received.”

One of the council members mouthed *compliment?!* behind a binder.

Another slowly reached for their phone like they were about to call for backup.

Phainon smiled at them all like they were overreacting.

“Relax, he’s not here to burn the place down. We’re besties,” he said cheerfully, eyes flicking back to Mydei.

Mydei’s expression darkened.

“You’re lucky I don’t dunk your face in the janitor’s mop bucket.”

“Tempting,” Phainon said, clearly enjoying this far too much. “But let’s save the romance for after study hour.”

The second-years started whispering furiously to each other.

Phainon, now leaning forward with chin in palm, gave Mydei the kind of smile that looked soft if you didn’t know better.

“Unless you’re free now?” he added sweetly.

Mydei stared at him like he was considering flipping the entire table. Then, after a long, tense pause, he just exhaled through his nose, snatched the note

back, and turned to leave.

“See you at tutoring, cutie,” Phainon called after him, sing-song.

The door slammed again.

A long silence followed.

“…Should we be worried?” someone whispered.

“Nah,” Phainon said with a serene smile, cracking open a soda. “He’s just flustered.”

Mydei walked fast.

Not the kind of fast that meant he was late—just fast enough that people didn’t bother trying to walk beside him.

Voices murmured behind his back as he passed, low and familiar. Half-curious, half-fearful. He caught the usual fragments.

“Wasn’t he in detention last month?”

“Nah, that was just a rumor—he corrected someone again, I think?”

“He always looks so pissed…”

He didn’t slow. Didn’t glance their way.

Not worth the breath.

What was worth his attention—unfortunately—was the image that kept replaying in his head like a cursed GIF on loop:

Phainon. Smiling. Looking at that note like it was *funny*. That smug “my hands slipped” bullshit.

Mydei exhaled through his nose.

What game was he playing at?

And why did it feel like he was *winning*?

He turned the corner toward his History classroom, tugged his hood down just enough to not get a talking-to from the teacher, and shoved the door open with a little more force than necessary.

At least History was safe ground.

He actually liked this class—structure, stories, people being stupid enough to repeat the same mistakes for centuries. Predictable. Comforting. He could sink into his notes and not think about—

Blue eyes. Crooked grin. A chocolate almond gently pressed against his lips.

He sat down hard, jaw tightening.

Okay. New plan.

He was going to pay attention, take notes, ace the quiz, and *absolutely not* think about Phainon again until tutoring.

Maybe not even then.

He tapped his pen against his notebook. The ink bled slightly in the margin.

After class, he'd stop by the library. Cool off. Kill some time before practice.

Anything to stop his brain from spiraling into:

"See you at tutoring, cutie."

He scowled.

There had to be a law against that kind of harassment.

Maybe he’d check the school handbook while he was at it.

The library was quiet, just the way he liked it—sun filtering down in soft slices through the high windows, the air heavy with the dust-and-paper scent of too many books and not enough readers.

Mydei stepped inside with the calm of someone entering a sacred space.

Finally.

No notes. No basketball. No flirty tutoring nonsense. No—

“—and that’s when I told him, ‘You can’t bribe a council member with coupons, man—’”

Mydei froze.

No.

He blinked toward the far table near the philosophy section.

There he was. *Phainon*. Head of the student council. Flanked by two of his friends, probably from that overly enthusiastic ecology club he led.

Mydei’s stomach twisted.

Phainon was laughing at something—head thrown back, sun catching in that mess of too-perfect hair. Easy and golden, like always.

Then, like the universe was on some sort of personal vendetta, Phainon *looked up.*

His whole expression lit up when he spotted Mydei. Like someone had just handed him a second dessert.

He waved. Too eagerly.

“Mydei!”

No.

Mydei spun on instinct, yanked the nearest book off the shelf—something hardbound and heavy—and briskly walked toward a tucked-away corner between ancient languages and “Reference Only” texts. The moment he sank into the bench seat, the familiar quiet curled around his shoulders.

Peace. At last.

He exhaled, flipping the book open. A second passed.

Then—

A voice, low and curious, just beside him.

“Whatcha reading?”

He flinched—just slightly. Caught himself before he did something stupid like launch the book into orbit.

Phainon crouched next to his seat like a cat that’d found something shiny, eyebrows raised, head tilted in innocent interest.

Mydei glared. “Why the fu—”

Phainon cut in before he could finish.

“Oh? The Kremnoan Dictionary? Nice pick. That’s a reconstructed logographic system—practically a dead language, but kinda elegant once you break the syntax apart. Not a lot of vocabulary though.” He smiled, bright and unbothered. “Didn’t know you were into that sort of thing.”

Mydei narrowed his eyes. “There is no word in the Kremnoan Dictionary for *nosy*.”

Phainon blinked. Then grinned, teeth showing. “Damn. That’s unfortunate.”

Before Mydei could tell him to get lost, Phainon motioned vaguely to the seat beside him.

“Mind if I…?” He didn’t wait for an answer—just gently nudged Mydei’s side with his shoulder and slid into the space next to him.

The chair wasn’t made for two people. Not really.

Their arms brushed.

Phainon leaned slightly closer, peering over at the page like he was genuinely interested.

And maybe he was.

Mydei stared at the open book. Then at the idiot pressed half-against his side.

He sighed. “You’re impossible.”

“I’ve been called worse,” Phainon said, voice low, almost warm.

They stayed like that for a second. Just sitting.

And somehow, in that narrow pocket of library silence, the space between them felt fuzzier than it should’ve been.

“…Fine,” Mydei muttered.

Phainon’s smile softened, just barely.

No teasing this time.

“Cool,” he said.

Then he reached across him to flip to the next page—elbow brushing Mydei’s ribs, shoulder warm and steady.

Neither of them moved away.

The hallway lights flickered as Mydei followed the path through the Chemistry wing. The after-hours hush of the school always felt a little uncanny—like the building had exhaled once everyone left, leaving only dust motes and locker creaks behind.

The usual tutoring room had a “DO NOT ENTER” sign taped to the door and a trail of paint-smeared footprints leading away. Art Club, apparently, had claimed it last-minute for their “poster-making spree.”

Phainon had texted: *“Plan B. Science lab. Trust me—it’s ambient.”*

He should’ve known better than to show up.

The lab door creaked open easily under his hand. Inside, the space was dim, lit only by the dying gold of the evening through narrow, high windows and a few weak fluorescents that buzzed low overhead.

Shadows cut the counters in angular shapes. It smelled like bleach and chalk dust and something faintly acidic.

“You’re late,” came Phainon’s voice, bright and light, from behind a microscope.

Mydei rolled his eyes. “You’re always early. That’s your fault.”

Phainon emerged from the corner, arms outstretched like he was showcasing a grand romantic surprise. “I got us a quiet room. Try not to cry from the sheer romance of it.”

Mydei raised a brow. “Only tears you’re getting are from me throwing hydrochloric acid on your face.”

Phainon beamed. “Aw, you remembered we’re in the Chemistry wing. How sentimental of you.”

They settled into a station near the back, where one of the counters had been cleared off. Phainon already had his materials out—notes, a few snacks, even highlighters. Why was he always so prepared? Like a walking Pinterest board.

It should’ve been annoying. It was annoying.

But it also made things… easier.

They worked in relative silence for a few minutes, the only sound the soft scratch of pen against notebook and the occasional creak of stool legs on tile.

Then Mydei dropped his pen.

It clattered off the edge, hit the floor, rolled under the counter.

He sighed and bent down—

Phainon had already crouched.

Their hands brushed.

Both froze.

The silence swelled. Just for a second.

The light hit Phainon’s face at a strange angle—half-shadowed, golden at the edges, hair mussed just enough to seem accidental. Up close like this, he looked… different. Realer. Too human to be the infuriating, perfect student he played so well.

Mydei snatched the pen before Phainon could.

He sat up wordlessly, pretending nothing happened.

But when Phainon slid back into his seat beside him, Mydei’s eyes caught on something he hadn’t seen before.

A thin strip of white bandage peeking from under Phainon’s collar. Delicate. Fresh.

Not the kind of thing you get from tripping over your dumb clipboard.

And when Phainon shifted to reach for a graph, the edge of a darker mark ghosted into view—just beneath the line of his jaw.

Mydei didn’t say anything. He didn’t ask.

He just felt it.

That tight pull in his chest.

The kind that made you want to find whoever did that and make sure they never *breathed* near them again.

Rumors be damned.

Still, he kept his tone dry as ever.

“Didn’t expect a golden boy like you to know what blood tastes like.”

Phainon didn’t miss a beat. His voice dropped, deadpan.

“Iron and salt.” He looked over, something unreadable in his eyes. “You?”

Mydei’s pen tapped once against the counter.

He shrugged. “Wouldn’t know. Must’ve been tasting copper.”

Phainon huffed, the sound soft and amused—but he didn’t look away for a moment too long.

Then, just like that, he smiled.

Back to easy, breezy, perfect.

“Alright. Page thirty-seven. Try not to break a pencil out of sheer angst this time.”

Mydei muttered something under his breath and leaned back into his notes.

But he didn’t miss the way Phainon was slightly quieter after that.

The shadows in the room lingered.

But so did the silence between them.

And somehow neither of them minded.

By the time the last equation was solved and the final sigh escaped Mydei's lips, the lab had grown darker. The overheads buzzed a little louder now, like the building was impatient to shut down for the night. Mydei capped his pen with a definitive *click*, then leaned back in his seat with his arms crossed, watching Phainon stretch again—always with that deliberate, cat-like laziness, as if he moved in frames drawn just a little too smug.

"That wasn't awful," Phainon said, flipping the textbook shut with a practiced flick. "You actually didn't threaten to kill me after question seven this time. Progress."

Mydei snorted, but the corner of his mouth twitched. "You're the one who said 'molecular bonding is sexy' with a straight face."

"Because it is."

"You're sick in the head."

Phainon leaned forward, resting his elbows on the table, chin in his hand. "Maybe. But you nailed those last three. That's a hell of a leap from the guy who almost stabbed his calculator last week."

He said it casually, but the praise still hit like a low hum in Mydei's chest. A part of him—traitorous, embarrassing—straightened at the words. Pride laced in defiance. He wouldn't let it show, obviously. But—

"…Yeah. Whatever," he mumbled, shoving his notes into his bag. Still, his movements weren't as sharp now. A bit slower. A bit more like someone who didn't mind the company he was leaving.

He made it to the doorway, hesitated, then tossed a lazy wave behind him.

"Later."

Phainon’s head tilted, a soft grin rising. “Look at that. He’s learning manners.”

But Mydei was already stepping into the hallway.

And promptly slamming into a wall of muscle.

The hallway had emptied out, lights dimmed save for the yellow glow near the end. Mydei staggered back a step as the figure in front of him—broad-shouldered, letterman jacket, smug smirk—blocked the path.

One of the seniors.

He recognized him. Faintly. A name that didn’t matter, because the energy said it all.

This was the kind of guy who liked power games. Who liked easy targets with bad reputations.

And Mydei, hoodie up, eyes sharp, still half damp from earlier practice, apparently looked like one.

“Well, well,” the senior said, grin widening. “Didn’t expect to see you crawling out of the lab. What—trying to graduate now?”

Mydei’s jaw tightened. He didn’t move. “You want something?”

The guy stepped closer.

Mydei didn’t flinch, but his hand twitched at his side. Almost reached for the strap of his bag.

But before the senior could say another word—

A second shadow joined them.

“Evening,” Phainon said, stepping out of the lab like he had all the time in the world. His voice was light. Friendly. Polite.

That same stupid clipboard was tucked under one arm.

“Sorry, is there a problem here?”

The senior froze. His posture shifted, confidence draining just enough to notice. Not fear—but recognition. The kind that made people reevaluate their next move. His smirk faltered. His eyes didn’t meet Phainon’s for long.

“Nah,” the guy said quickly. “Just—passing by.”

Phainon smiled. Still warm. Still perfectly cordial. “Great. Then maybe pass a little faster?”

The senior took the hint. Backed up. Walked off.

Didn’t look back.

Mydei blinked after him. Then turned, eyes narrowing.

“What the hell was that?”

Phainon, still smiling, gave him a shrug. “Extra credit.”

“…What does that even mean?”

“It means I used my words and made a friend,” Phainon said cheerfully.

Mydei eyed him. “That guy looked like he was one more syllable away from pissing himself.”

Phainon pressed a hand to his chest. “Are you accusing me of having a shady past?”

“I’m accusing you of being way too good at fake smiling.”

Phainon’s grin tilted sideways, sharp and knowing. “I am the student council president. We’re trained for that.”

Mydei squinted at him. “…You’ve definitely been in a fight.”

“I don’t know what you’re talking about.”

“You just smiled a senior into submission.”

“Again. *Friendly conversation*.”

Phainon started walking backward down the hall, still facing him. “I’ll see you Thursday. Try not to fall in love before then.”

Mydei scoffed. “Keep dreaming.”

Phainon’s voice floated over his shoulder as he turned the corner.

“I do!”

And with that, he was gone.

Leaving Mydei alone in the hallway, jaw clenched, heart pounding for reasons that had nothing to do with the stupid equations he’d just spent an hour memorizing.

God he was in deep.

Mydei blinked awake, cheek pressed against the cold surface of the desk. His neck ached. The room was quiet—soft light filtering in through the blinds—and there was something warm draped over his shoulders. He frowned, lifting it slightly.

A jacket.

Thick, soft-lined, smelled faintly like spice and citrus and something frustratingly familiar.

His brows furrowed as he sat up, rubbing his face. The clock on the wall read 5:12.

Shit.

He jolted, hands scrambling for his phone. He'd gotten here early, wanting a quiet space to focus before tutoring started, but—he'd passed out? He swiped to check the time again.

Wait. Their session was supposed to start an hour ago.

Phainon hadn't shown.

His gaze dropped back to the jacket. It was navy blue, a little oversized, and weirdly familiar. He'd seen this before. Worn half-zipped on a certain annoying student council president's shoulders.

The door creaked open.

"Sorry I'm late," Phainon called out cheerfully, already halfway inside. "Got roped into a last-minute council thing. You know how it is. Democracy."

Mydei gave him a flat look, still clutching the jacket. "This is yours."

Phainon glanced at it, then shrugged as he slung his bag down onto the desk. "Nope. Never seen it in my life."

"Bullshit," Mydei muttered.

Phainon slid into the seat next to him, all easy charm and bright eyes. "Anyway," he said, cracking open his notebook like nothing happened. "You ready to get started?"

Mydei squinted at him. Long. Hard.

Eventually, he sighed. "Yeah."

Phainon smiled, satisfied. "Great."

He didn't say a word about the jacket again.

And neither did Mydei.

“Okay,” Phainon said, tapping his pen against the notebook. “Try this one without crying this time.”

Mydei scowled, glancing down at the equation. “I’m not crying. That was one time. I was six.”

“Oh, so you *do* remember losing at Beyblades.”

“You shoved me into a wall.”

“You burst into tears *before* that.”

“I was six,” Mydei repeated, voice flattening with menace.

Phainon grinned. “It was kind of cute, though. All dramatic and full of rage. Like a very short Greek tragedy.”

“I will throw you out this window.”

“That’s fair.”

They went quiet for a few minutes after that, the only sounds the faint scratch of pencils and the buzz of the overhead lights. The classroom had that mellow, end-of-day hush to it—sunlight drowsing along the floor tiles, dust drifting in the air. It would’ve almost felt peaceful if Mydei wasn’t visibly tensing again.

Phainon noticed it in the way he clutched the pencil tighter. The way his shoulders hunched in ever so slightly. And then—

“Shit,” Mydei muttered, erasing something too hard. He tried again. Stopped halfway. Swore under his breath and pressed his fingers to his temples.

Phainon leaned over slightly. “Hey. You’re not—”

“I *know* how to do this,” Mydei cut in, not looking at him. “I’ve done every step right, but the answer’s still wrong, and I—I don’t get it. I don’t get *why*.”

There was a tightness in his voice, just under the surface. Not angry. Just—tired. This wasn’t just about the math anymore.

Phainon watched him for a second. Quiet. Then he said, carefully, “It’s okay. We can take a—”

“Why are you even helping me?”

The words hit like a dropped weight. Sudden. Sharp. But not cruel.

Just real.

Phainon didn’t answer right away. The smile that usually lived on his face eased off, gentling into something less polished.

“Maybe I missed you,” he said.

Mydei stilled.

For a second, the silence felt loaded. Like a wire pulled taut. One wrong word from either of them would snap it clean.

Mydei pushed his chair back.

“I don’t need this,” he muttered, voice turning cold and even. “I’m not some pathetic charity case, and if you’re doing this out of pity or guilt or whatever leftover childhood sentiment, you can keep it.”

He stood up, barely giving Phainon a glance.

Phainon caught his wrist before he made it a step.

Gentle. Like he was trying to anchor him, not stop him.

“Mydei—” His voice was quiet. “That’s not what this is.”

But Mydei didn’t look back. Not yet.

Then he spun around, jaw tight, voice clipped. “You think you can just—”

Phainon’s hand hit his shoulder before he could finish. Not rough, but fast—like he moved before his brain caught up. Mydei staggered back a step, spine catching the edge of the desk, his breath slipping out in a sharp exhale.

“What the fu—”

Didn’t matter.

Phainon kissed him.

No warning. No wind-up. Just heat.

His mouth hit with the kind of force that came from something pent-up and buried too long. Fingers curled hard in Mydei’s shirt—too tight, like he didn’t realize he was gripping at all. His weight pushed forward, body close, close enough that Mydei could feel how much he was holding back and how much he wasn’t.

It was clumsy. Messy. Real.

Phainon tasted like sugar and sweat, breath hot from moving fast, like he’d run to this moment. One hand hit the desk beside Mydei’s hip, the other caught just above his waistband, palm dragging over warm skin where his shirt had ridden up. Mydei’s back arched instinctively, trying to keep balance. His hands shot out, gripping Phainon’s jacket to brace himself.

The desk shifted under them with a creak. Mydei’s legs tensed. Their chests bumped—once, twice—before Phainon’s mouth angled, pressing deeper, his breath staggering through his nose like he hadn’t meant to need this so badly.

Mydei made a sound—surprised, caught off guard. But not pulling away.

Phainon didn’t stop until his lungs forced him to.

When he pulled back, his breath dragged. His eyes didn’t match the version of him everyone else knew—sharp, bright, untouchable. That shine was gone. What was left was stripped down. Something darker. Restless. Raw.

Mydei was still breathing hard. “What the hell are you doing.”

Phainon didn’t answer.

He kissed him again.

Slower. More precise. His hand came up and caught Mydei’s jaw—not rough, just steady, holding him still like he didn’t want him to move. Their lips dragged, pressure easing but never softening. The kind of kiss that said he’d been thinking about it for too long and finally couldn’t stop.

When they broke apart this time, their foreheads almost touched. Mydei felt dizzy.

Phainon muttered, “…Sorry.”

Mydei stared at him, chest rising and falling too fast.

“You don’t kiss like someone who’s sorry.”

Phainon let out a quiet breath. It wasn’t a laugh. Not quite.

“Didn’t mean to grab you like that,” he said, voice lower now. “Didn’t mean to… do it like that.”

He stepped back—too quickly, like he didn’t trust himself to stay close. Ran a hand through his hair. Didn’t look up right away.

Mydei watched him. Noticed the way his collar had come loose. His knuckles were scuffed. He hadn’t seen that before.

“You always grab people when they piss you off?” Mydei asked, voice flat but not as steady as he wanted.

Phainon met his eyes. “Only the ones I like.”

The silence sat between them. Thick. Uneasy.

“You kiss like you’ve done it before,” Mydei muttered.

“I haven’t,” Phainon said. Then after a pause: “Not like that.”

He shrugged his jacket back into place. Tried to fix the buttons. Gave up. He looked different. Like something had cracked and spilled out.

And Mydei couldn’t stop looking.

Mydei shifted—just barely—but enough. Like he was about to say something, or maybe do something worse. His gaze dropped to Phainon’s mouth, then flicked up again, jaw tight. The air between them felt too close, like the silence might crack under its own weight.

He leaned in the slightest bit.

And that’s when footsteps sounded in the hallway.

Both of them froze.

A knock. The door creaked open.

Phainon stepped back fast, wiping his mouth with the back of his hand like he could erase the moment. His expression flipped—smooth, polite, too quick. But there was tension in the corner of his jaw that didn’t match the act.

The teacher peered in, raising an eyebrow. “Everything alright in here?”

Phainon’s voice came easy. Casual. “Just solving for x.”

Mydei didn’t answer. Couldn’t. His face was flushed to the ears, chest still rising like he hadn’t gotten enough air back yet.

The teacher looked between them, paused, then gave a short nod. “Alright. Lock up when you’re done.”

Door shuts.

Silence again.

Phainon glanced over, a hint of a smirk tugging at the corner of his mouth—but it didn't reach his eyes.

Mydei hadn't moved. Still red-faced. Still catching up.

The hallway was mostly empty by the time they stepped out. Doors shut. Lights dimmed to save power. Their footsteps echoed, a little too loud in the hush.

Neither spoke.

Phainon walked beside him, but a step behind—shoulders slightly hunched, hands shoved in his pockets. His usual confidence had bled out somewhere between the classroom and now. No smartass grin. No teasing banter. He looked… unsettled. Not regretful, but unsure. Like he didn't know if he was allowed to breathe around Mydei anymore.

Mydei slowed his pace.

Out the corner of his eye, he caught the flicker of tension in Phainon's jaw, like he was trying not to ask the question written all over his face.

Did I just screw this up?

Mydei's thumb brushed unconsciously against his lower lip. It was still faintly sensitive, tingling. He scowled at himself and dropped his hand fast, ears flushing.

They stopped near the stairwell—still quiet, no one in sight.

Phainon opened his mouth to say something, but Mydei stepped in.

Closer.

Phainon flinched—not dramatically, but enough. Like he expected a punch to the gut or worse. His breath hitched. That stupid politician mask flickered back on, trying to make it look like nothing mattered—but his eyes gave him away. Wide, unsure, bracing.

Mydei tilted his head slightly, voice low.

“You’re not getting away with that.”

Phainon blinked. The words didn’t seem to register.

Mydei took another step. Their jackets brushed. His tone dropped even quieter—measured, not gentle.

“You kiss me like that,” he murmured, “then act like it didn’t happen?”

Phainon looked like he was waiting for a blow. Or judgment. Or for Mydei to walk away and never look back.

Instead, Mydei leaned in, breath just brushing the shell of Phainon’s ear.

“I should’ve known sooner,” he said. “Would’ve done something about it.”

Phainon made a sound—quiet, involuntary—like his brain had short-circuited.

Mydei didn’t let him gather it.

“Next time,” he said, voice low and edged, heat behind every syllable, “I get to shut you up.”

Phainon froze. Then his eyes dragged up—slow, disbelieving—and landed on Mydei’s mouth like he was trying not to.

Mydei held his gaze for a long second.

Then he stepped back.

“See you next session,” he said, all sharp angles and composure, already turning away.

Phainon stood there like he’d forgotten how to function. Jacket wrinkled, hair mussed, jaw slack.

He didn’t say anything.

Didn’t need to.

Because the look he gave Mydei’s back as he walked off—shoulders relaxed for the first time all night—wasn’t clean-cut or golden-boy at all.

It was feral. Starving.

And next session couldn’t come fast enough.

End Notes

Might revise this at some point cause I was gonna add Mydei's friends and the other Chrysos Heirs till I got lazy, but hope u guys still liked it <3 Gotta birthday party to attend rn😍

(While I actually work on getting all the tech terms worked out for Paper/Pyres, if I ever do an animals au should I do Lion Mydei and Oryx Phainon or Cat Mydei and Dog Phainon? Was gonna do a detective au but don't have the time to research and refuse to do a half assed job at it😭)

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